recognise, even at the first glance, that he is the King…. His eyes so bright and flashing that they seem like a sea shimmering in the sunlight.' And Akbar would demand of his men a similar, unconditional courage, even the poets, the musicians, the historians, and the philosophers.

After the battle was won at Ahmedabad, Muhammad Hussain Mirza was captured and brought before Akbar where Raja Birbal asked him, 'Which of these men captured you?' The question was asked because a number of soldiers were crowding around the prisoner, claiming to be the champion of the moment. Muhammad Hussain Mirza, however, replied with simple fatalism that 'the salt of His Majesty has captured me'. Akbar spoke kindly to his defeated foe and then handed him into the custody of Rai Singh. There was no such equanimity a moment later, however, when Akbar saw another group of prisoners. Included in this bedraggled group of men was the koka of Ibrahim Hussain, one Mard Azmai Shah. This was the man who had killed Bhupat, Raja Bhagwant Das' brother, and Akbar's flaring rage demanded immediate retribution. He spun around, grabbed a spear, and flung it at the man, who was immediately set upon by the crowd of jeering soldiers who slashed him to death.

As he grew older, Akbar would become aware of the need to control his sudden, unpredictable rages and he would write long letters to his own sons, advising temperance and patience. But in Gujarat, faced with the man who had killed one of his closest courtiers, his own brother-in-law, Akbar's wrath was beyond reason. A tower of heads was constructed with some 1,000 heads of the fallen enemy, as a warning to all rebels. The heads of Muhammad Hussain Mirza and Ikhtiyar ul-Mulk* were sent to Agra. Masaud Husain Mirza, captured alive, would later be brought before Akbar along with 300 of his followers. They were dragged into court, to the horror, bemusement, and chilled amusement of the courtiers, bound in chains with collars around their necks, covered in filth and flies, and wearing the skins of animals over their bodies and heads—'the skins of asses, hogs and dogs', specified Badauni. Some of them were put to death and the rest were freed.

The years of warfare required to bring about the decimation of the empire's enemies had an effect on the province of Gujarat as well. Ravaged by years of war, as the huge imperial army swept through the country repeatedly, the province suffered a catastrophic famine in 1574 of which contemporary writer Qandahari leaves us a moving account.